

Principles of Microeconomics (Econ 1020)

Fall 2026, Vanderbilt University

Instructor:

Dr. John Stromme, john.stromme@vanderbilt.edu

Office Hours: See Brightspace. They may change throughout the term.

Brightspace:

All information related to assignments, materials, deadlines, and grades for this course will be updated on Brightspace.

Course Overview:

This course is an introduction to Microeconomics. More than anything, this course aims to teach you how to “think like an economist”. When possible, we will seek not to memorize facts but rather learn how to apply economic thinking to explain, predict, and improve what happens in the world, or even more simply, in your daily life. We will accomplish this by learning basic microeconomic models, which we will explore using algebra and graphs. While these models are theoretical, we will apply them to real-life examples and investigate them empirically.

Topics: *Optimization, Equilibrium, Demand/Supply, Markets, Externalities, Public Goods, Monopolies, Game Theory.*

Resources

The best thing is to make a study group with your friends; if you can’t fully explain a concept/problem to your friend, then you don’t understand it. For extra help there are two main resources:

1. TA office hours (TA info **TBA**, see brightspace)
2. Prof. Stromme’s office hours

Outside of the course, students have reported that using youtube/kahn academy has been helpful to them. Students have reported mixed results using other independent tutoring resources (e.g. Athletic dept tutors or <https://www.vanderbilt.edu/tutoring>)

Email Policy:

Content Questions: Prof Stromme has over 200 students this term. While in an ideal world Prof Stromme would like to give unlimited attention to every student, it is simply not possible. Email is particularly inefficient, therefore Prof. Stromme will likely direct you to get your question answered in person (lecture/office hours).

Personal or Admin Questions: Emails are welcome if Prof. Stromme can be helpful for personal (but course related) or administrative questions. For a sensitive matter, contact Prof. Stromme to make a special appointment.

Response Time: Don’t rely on last-minute urgent emails! Although Prof. Stromme is often quick to reply, you cannot count on an immediate response. If you do not receive a reply within 2 business days, send a reminder email.

Textbook:

- Microeconomics, by Acemoglu, Laibson and List (3rd ed), ISBN: 9780137390625
 - The textbook is **not formally required**.
 - We do follow the material in the textbook chapter-by-chapter, but generally with slight variations and more depth.
 - The textbook simply provides another voice to get a general sense of the ideas/material, for those that find such a thing helpful for their learning.

Evaluation:

20% Problem Sets

Due roughly every Friday. All deadlines and submissions will be in gradescope. (*See brightspace for submission instructions.*)

80% Exams

There will be **three** multiple-choice Exams. In-person, in-class, closed-note.

Exam Grade Calculation:

- Option 1: Three Midterms
Your best exam will be weighted at 30%, and the other two at 25%.
- Option 2: Two Midterms & Comprehensive Final
In lieu of taking Midterm 3, You will take a Comprehensive Final.
If your Final would raise your grade it will be worth 40% and Midterm 1 and 2 will each be 20%.
If you do poorly on the final your best exam will be weighted at 30% and the other two at 25%.

3% (Extra Credit) Participation

During each class, we will use tophat for participation. Participating in tophat questions will earn you extra credit towards your final grade.

Please note that I frame the tophat as “extra credit” because, philosophically, I believe that if a student gets 100% on all exams/psets they should get a 100% in the course, regardless of attendance. However, for your case, consider carefully how a marginal tophat point might affect your grade.

Excused Work / Drops Policy

Due to the size of the course, there is a simple blanket “drops” policy to account for sick days, travel, interviews, one-off unexpected crises, or other similar excused absences.

• PSets:

- **No extensions will be given for problem sets for any reason**
- Your lowest PSet score will be dropped
- You can email any missing PSets at the end of the term for a 50% credit

• Tophat:

- About 5 classes worth of tophat points will be dropped/excused.

If extenuating circumstances lead to 2+ weeks of absence, you need to get in touch with the student deans to guide you through arranging for special accommodation.

Grading Criteria:

Tophat: Graded only on completeness, never correctness.

PSets: Graded on a mix of completeness and correctness

- Multiple choice Qs: *graded for correctness*
- Free response Qs: *graded for completeness*

Exams: Graded only on correctness

- *Note that exams will consist only of multiple choice Qs due to course size*

Grade Cutoffs: Grading in the course will follow A&S guidelines where an “A” corresponds to *Excellent* Performance and a “B” *Good* Performance.

As a baseline, grades will be determined by raw scores with traditional cutoffs, e.g., A *93*; A- *90*; B+ *87*; etc... (*This also implies that the course would **never** be curved downwards.*)

However, it is usually appropriate to apply an upward curve to the raw exam scores so grades are more reflective of actual performance. In this case, “free” points are applied to exam scores resulting in a *curved* overall exam grade for each student.

After each midterm I will give a rough sense of what letter grade your exam score corresponds to so you have proper feedback on your performance. However, the exam curves will not be finalized until after the term as *all* coursework must be taken into consideration when reflecting on overall course difficulty and applying the appropriate curve.

Important Dates:

- **MIDTERM 1: September 30th** (Wednesday, in class)
- **Fall Break: October 22–23rd** (I.e., No Class Friday)
- **MIDTERM 2: November 4th** (Wednesday, in class)
- **Thanksgiving Break: November 21st–29th** (Full Week Off)
- **MID 3/FINAL EXAM:** (Will take place during our official “final exam slot”)
 - 9:05:** Tuesday December 15th, 3:00–5:00p
 - 10:10:** Wednesday December 16th, 3:00–5:00p

Students With Disabilities:

I am committed to creating an effective learning environment for all learning styles. If you have a learning or physical disability you should contact Vanderbilt's Student Access Office (SAO).

To ensure equity across all students, I can only make such accommodations as directed by SAO. Any student wishing to utilize testing accommodations **must** take the exam at SAO as proper accommodations cannot be provided in the regular classroom. It is the student's responsibility to schedule their exams with SAO at the beginning of the semester. If you fail to make proper arrangements with SAO you must take the exam in the regular exam session without any accommodations.

Religious Observances:

If an exam or problem set conflicts with a religious observance, let me know and we'll work together to make an accommodation. This should be done as soon as possible, and no later than two weeks before the conflict.

Other Accommodations:

Life happens. Occasionally it may be appropriate for a student to receive accommodations for unique circumstances. In such a case, you should reach out as soon as possible and we can work together to determine if an accommodation is appropriate.

Academic Integrity, Allowed Resources, and AI:

Vanderbilt's Honor Code governs all work in this course (e.g., tests, papers, and homework assignments). You should be aware that the penalty for cheating at Vanderbilt is severe, and irrespective of any formal penalty, inhibits your own learning.

- **Problem Sets:** Collaboration with others, human or AI, is welcome. However, problem sets are important for learning the material and if you overly rely on outside help you will struggle when it comes to the examinations.
- **Exams:** No outside resources allowed. Exam work must be solely your own effort.

Lastly, note that use of past course resources not currently made available to all students in this course is also not allowed and will be viewed as cheating.